LESSON 13

Past Continuous

We use the Past Continuous:

- to describe a continuing situation in the past, or at a given time in the past

I **was** sleep**ing** all afternoon.

I **was** just giv**ing** a presentation at 3 last Monday.

At midnight we **were** still writ**ing** our homework.

- to describe two continuing situations happening at the same time

Carol **was** cook**ing** while her husband **was** watch**ing** the football match.

While she **was** do**ing** the rooms, we **were** pick**ing** apples in the garden.

While we **were** writ**ing** our homework, George **was** play**ing** football.

- to talk about actions in the past during which shorter events happened – something happened in the middle of something else; for the shorter events/actions we use Past Simple:

Matt **phoned** while we **were having** dinner.

It **was raining** when I **got up**.

I **was** walk**ing** in the park when I **met** Peter.

We **were** watch**ing** a film when the light **went** off.

While I **was waiting** for the bus, I **saw** Edward.

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But: We use the Past Simple to say that one thing happened after another.

> I **saw** Pete in the supermarket. I **went** to him, and we **had** a chat. We **decided** to watch the match together in the evening

Time expressions often used with the Past Continuous: ***while, when***.

Formation rules: **was/were + V-ing** (Also see the tables below.)

Affirmative: e.g. Laura **was** read**ing** all day. My friends **were** wait**ing** for me.

Negative: e.g. Laura **was not** (**wasn't)** read**ing** all day. My friends **were not** (**weren't**) wait**ing** for me.

Interrogative: e.g. **Was** Laura read**ing** all day? **Were** my friends wait**ing** for me?

NOTE: some short verbs double their last letter before the -ing ending. E.g. chat – chatting, beg – begging, drop – dropping.

Affirmative

I He/She/(It)	was	chatting on Facebook all afternoon.
We You They	were	

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Negative

I He/She/(It)	was not (wasn't)	chatting on Facebook all afternoon.
We You They	were not (weren't)	

Interrogative

Was	I he/she/(it)	chatting on Facebook all afternoon?
Were	we you they	

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